BRIEFING

European Parliament

European marine fishing areas: The Black Sea

SUMMARY

The Black Sea's natural characteristics, its isolated position and the high percentage of waters where no life is possible, make it a unique and vulnerable place.

Fisheries in the region face a number of challenges, including environmental issues such as pollution, over-exploitation, eutrophication, invasive species and climate change, that are linked directly to the sector's sustainability.

The EU fleet comprises Bulgarian and Romanian vessels and is small compared with the other fleets in the region, consisting of Georgian, Russian, Turkish and Ukrainian vessels.

The EU's role in the management of Black Sea fisheries is limited, given that only two EU Member States are involved and are bound by EU legislation. Moreover, the EU's membership in the regional sea convention is blocked.

Cooperation between the countries around the Black Sea on transboundary issues is essential, but this has been rendered more difficult than ever by Russia's ongoing war on Ukraine.

The European Parliament has repeatedly drawn attention to the fishery sector's challenges in the Black Sea.

IN THIS BRIEFING

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Introduction

The isolated position and its waters' specific characteristics make the Black Sea unique: the largest part of its water is not habitable, and space for living organisms is limited. Fisheries in the region are facing several issues, from environmental problems to over-exploiting and a scattered management situation. The EU's Black Sea fleet, consisting of Bulgarian and Romanian vessels, accounts for only a small part of the overall fleet, which is one of the reasons why the EU's role in managing fisheries is limited. Russia's ongoing war on Ukraine further aggravates the situation for fisheries.

Main characteristics

The Black Sea, located in Europe's south-eastern extremity, is the world's most isolated sea. Its only connection to the Atlantic Ocean is via the Mediterranean Sea through a passageway consisting of the Bosporus Strait, the Sea of Marmara and the Dardanelles Strait. To the north, it connects with the Sea of Azov through the Kerch Strait (see Figure 1). The Black Sea receives significant fresh water supply from large rivers (the Danube, Dnieper and Don), and saline water from the Mediterranean through the Bosporus. The sea has a strong stratification, with little water exchange between the low-salinity surface waters and the saltier deep waters. Below 150 meters, no life is possible; this is due to a lack of oxygen and a high content of hydrogen sulphide. With more than 80 % of its waters hostile to life, the Black Sea contains the largest mass of lifeless water on earth. Marine life is concentrated in the small oxygenated, low-salinity surface waters.

Owing to the sea's specific characteristics, the Black Sea's species diversity is considerably lower than that of the neighbouring Mediterranean.

The Black Sea is bordered by six countries: two EU Member States, Bulgaria and Romania, alongside Georgia, Russia, Türkiye and Ukraine.

Its coastal zone is densely populated with about 16 million inhabitants, augmented by a further 4 million tourists during the summer months.

Figure 1 – The Black Sea and the countries bordering it

Source: EPRS, 2025.

Environmental challenges

The Black Sea's specific natural features, in particular the little exchange of water, make it susceptible to disturbances of its environment. Pollution, over-exploiting, eutrophication and unsustainable fishing, along with invasive species and the impact of climate change, have adversely affected the sea, both resulting in a decline of the sea's biological resources and putting fisheries at risk. The fallout from the ongoing war in the region – such as the destruction of the Nova Kakhovka dam in southern Ukraine, oil spills or the presence of sea mines – exacerbates environmental threats. Moreover, the war has disrupted necessary cooperation efforts between bordering countries in view of tackling the transboundary problems. Despite some positive results regarding for instance the decreasing inputs of pollution and nutrients, the sea is far from the 'good environmental status' the EU's Marine Strategy Framework Directive is aimed at achieving.[1]

Pollution

The presence of potentially harmful substances and marine litter - mainly plastics and microplastics – is a major threat for living organisms and ecosystems in the Black Sea. Natural characteristics, such as the near-complete lack of tides, obstruct natural depuration processes while enhancing the accumulation of substances and litter. The intense expansion of urbanised areas and related economic activities in coastal areas, together with (partially) inadequate waste and wastewater treatment, are among the main causes of pollution.

According to a 2019 study by the United Nations Development Programme, the amount of marine litter in the Black Sea is almost twice as high as in the Mediterranean Sea. The large majority (about 83 %) of the litter is plastic, namely bottles, packaging and bags, likely to enter the sea via the big rivers. Microplastic particles, tending to accumulate in organisms, were found in particularly high concentrations in urbanised coastal areas. Moreover, a 2021 EU-founded study concluded that more than half of the living organisms assessed in the Black Sea were affected by chemical contaminants. Some priority hazardous chemical substances dangerous for marine and human life were found at above-threshold values. These include benzo(a)pyrene, linked to oil spill or leakage accidents; pesticides, which may enter the sea via rivers as agricultural runoff; and flame retardants used in household products, which may end up in the sea through waste disposal or inappropriate wastewater management.

Over-exploitation

Overfishing in the Black Sea can be traced back to the 1950s. It is considered to be at the origin of major ecosystem changes, making it one of the main threats for both the marine environment and the livelihood of fishers. According to the General Fisheries Commission for the Mediterranean (GFCM), most commercial species are either being over-exploited (turbot, anchovy, horse mackerel, whiting), depleted (piked dogfish), or exploited at an uncertain stock level (European sprat, red mullet). One of the commercially most valuable fish species in the Black Sea – turbot – experienced a significant decline in stock between 2013 and 2016.[2] A 2024 Greenpeace report links the issue of overfishing to overcapacity, in particular of the Turkish fleets.

Illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing adds to the critical state of fish resources, and is considered one of the most serious threats for sustainable fishing in the entire Black Sea. For instance, IUU is one of the main cause of the collapse of the sturgeon species.

Eutrophication

The excessive input of nutrients, in particular nitrogen, remains a major issue, especially in the Black Sea's coastal areas. This kind of pollution is deemed mainly due to runoff from agricultural land and inappropriate wastewater management. Excessive amounts of nutrients can lead to mass growth of algae (known as an 'algal bloom'). These, in turn, may prevent sunlight from reaching deeper zones, and lead to a decrease of available oxygen as a result of decomposition processes, among other effects. Some 70 % of the nutrients flow to the Black Sea from the six coastal countries, while 30 % enter it through the Danube River from countries with no direct access to the sea. Eutrophication is a major cause for the decline of the Black Sea's unique Phyllophora fields, an important habitat for a large number of juvenile and bottom-dwelling fish.

Invasive species

About half of the 300 non-indigenous species in the Black Sea have become invasive,[3] and are competing with native species for food and space. Moreover, some non-indigenous species, such as lionfish, pufferfish and several jellyfish species, can present immediate dangers to human health. The most prominent example in the Black Sea is the comb jelly (*Mnemiopsis leidyi*), introduced in the late 1980s. It caused major changes in the ecosystem and contributed to a decline of the Black Sea fisheries, mainly driven by food competition and direct predation on fish larvae. While *Mnemiopsis* levels have been reduced by the introduction of a predator species, other non-indigenous species – such as the rapa whelk (*Rapana venosa*), a sea snail – have become major commercial species. The main means and routes by which non-indigenous species are introduced include migration (for instance species entering from the Mediterranean), shipping (e.g. via ballast water) and escape from aquaculture plants. A general trend shows the number of non-indigenous species increasing in recent years.

Climate change

Climate change effects that typically occur in marine environments can be observed in the Black Sea, as well. They include changes in ecosystems' species composition due to rising water temperature or acidification resulting from increased CO_2 absorption; the latter has a negative impact on organisms with calcareous body parts, such as corals or mussels. Rising temperatures are also thought to be the cause of a specific change in the Black Sea's environment: over the past 20 years, a 20-25 metre rise of the hydrogen sulphide layer has been observed. Moreover, in some places, the upper oxygenated layer is decreasing, thus further reducing the living space for marine animals and plants.

EU fisheries in figures

Two EU Member states – Bulgaria and Romania – are involved in Black Sea fisheries. In 2022, the EU Black Sea fleet comprised 1 345 vessels, 1 222 of which were small-scale vessels making up over 90 % of the total EU fleet.

Small-scale coastal fisheries within the EU Black Sea fleet are particularly important from a social point of view. They provide 83 % of the total employment and in most cases are managed as a family business. However, in 2022, they accounted for as little as 30 % of the total landed weight in the region and for 40 % of the total value, while the large-scale fleet accounted for 70 % and 60 % respectively.

A long-term decreasing trend regarding EU Black Sea fishing efforts, landings in weight and average wages, has been observed since 2018.

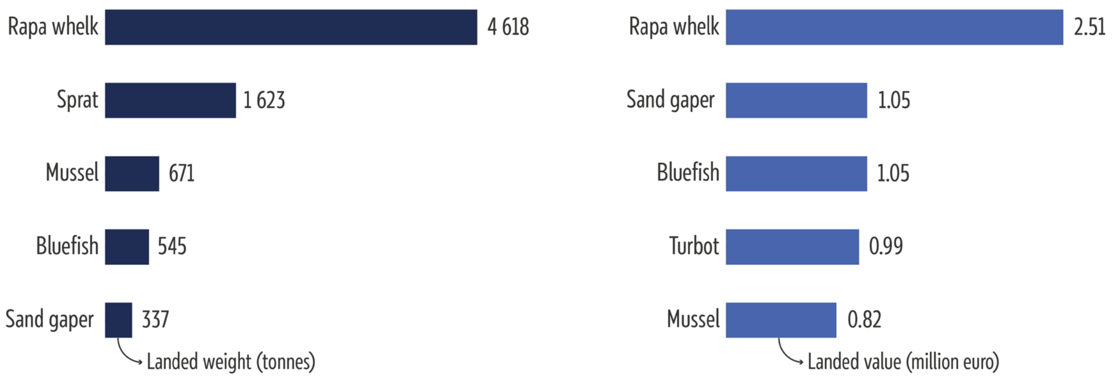
In 2022, EU Black Sea fishers spent less days at sea, which led to a considerable reduction of landings in weight by 18 % compared with 2021. Black Sea fisheries face direct impacts from the war. Romanian vessels, in particular, used to fish close to Ukrainian waters, and are now advised to stay clear of the conflict zone. Fisheries have also been affected by high energy prices, making the sector even less profitable.

In 2022, the weight of landings generated by the Black Sea EU fleet amounted to some 8 722 tonnes, split between Bulgaria (5 546 tonnes) and Romania (3 176 tonnes).

The main landed species (by weight) in 2022 were sea snails (4 618 tonnes), followed by European sprat (1 623 tonnes), Mediterranean mussel (671 tonnes) and bluefish (545 tonnes).

In terms of landed value, the most commercially important species were sea snails (€2.51 million), sand gaper (€1.05 million), bluefish (€1.05 million), turbot (€0.99 million) and Mediterranean mussel (€0.82 million).

Figure 2 – Top 10 species in landed weight and value, for EU Member States' fleets operating in the Black Sea (tonnes, €)



Data source: European Commission Joint Research Centre, The 2024 annual economic report on the EU fishing fleet, 2024, p. 169.

However, when EU and non-EU fleets are considered together, a different picture of the Black Sea fishing fleet emerges. Within the GFCM area, the Black Sea fleet amounts to almost 11 000 vessels, eight times more than the EU fleet alone (based on data collected from Bulgaria, Georgia Romania, Türkiye and Ukraine[4]). With about 3 %, the EU fleet in the Black Sea accounted for only a **very small part** of landings for the 2020-2021 period: by far the largest share of landings by weight in the Black Sea was provided by Türkiye (61.9 %), followed by Georgia (19.9 %), Russia (13.1 %), Ukraine (2.3 %), Bulgaria (1.9 %) and Romania (0.9 %).

Accordingly, a different picture emerges for the main landed species in the Black Sea: between 2020 and 2021, the most landed species was the European anchovy (65%), followed by European sprat (13 %) and rapa whelk (2.9 %).

Fisheries management

EU fishing activities in the Black Sea are subject to the EU's common fisheries policy (CFP), which aims to ensure that EU fisheries are sustainable from an environmental, economic and social point of view. As mentioned earlier, only two of the six countries bordering the Black Sea — Bulgaria and Romania — are EU-Member States. The management of the Black Seas fisheries has long been considered as lacking in effectiveness because of multiple decision layers, with unclear roles and responsibilities divided between national states, the EU and GFCM (see also below). New initiatives have emerged since 2016.

At EU level, the Council for some fish species sets the number of total allowable catches (TACs), or fishing opportunities, for the following year. The setting of TACs for a particular geographical area is a prerogative of the Council and not subject to the ordinary legislative procedure, where the European Parliament and the Council adopt legislation on an equal footing as co-legislators. The fishing opportunities take into account obligations arising from international obligations and multiannual plans.

For the Black Sea, TACs are set for two fish species: **turbot** and **sprat**. The quotas for turbot and sprat TACs were introduced in 2008, following the accession of Bulgaria and Romania to the EU. While the quota for turbot is divided equally between Bulgaria and Romania, the national quotas for sprat are set at 70 % for Bulgaria and 30 % for Romania.

In December 2024, the Council agreed to increase the quotas for 2025 by 3.85 % compared with 2024 in the case of turbot, and to maintain the closure period for turbot fishing from 15 April to 15 June. For sprat, the catch limits remained the same as for 2024.

Moreover, at EU level, the Black Sea Advisory Council (BLSAC) was established in 2015. The BLSAC is a stakeholder-led organisation that provides the European Commission and the EU countries with recommendations on fisheries management matters in view of meeting CFP objectives.

The EU's common maritime agenda (CMA) for the Black Sea was established in 2019, as a sea basin initiative to enhance regional cooperation with a view to achieving a sustainable blue economy in the Black Sea. Its priorities include protecting the marine ecosystem, addressing marine pollution and plastic litter, and supporting sustainable fisheries and aquaculture in the Black Sea. The CMA for the Black Sea is a partnership between Bulgaria, Georgia, Moldova, Romania, Russia,[5] Türkiye and Ukraine.

Given the cross-border nature of fisheries in the Black Sea, the management of fish resources requires international cooperation at a regional level. For Black Sea fisheries, the EU's participation in the GFCM is of particular importance. Established in 1949 under the auspices of the UN Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO), the GFCM seeks to ensure the conservation and sustainable use of living marine resources in the Mediterranean and the Black Sea. It has the authority to adopt compulsory decisions, which the EU as a contracting party is bound to transpose into EU law. Three Black Sea-bordering countries – Bulgaria, Romania and Türkiye – are GFCM members, while Georgia, Moldova and Ukraine have the status of cooperating non-contracting parties.

The GFCM draws up multiannual management plans aimed at ensuring the sustainable exploitation of fishery resources in its area of competence. It also establishes fisheries-restricted areas to protect specific stocks, habitats and deep-sea ecosystems. The GFCM has adopted a multiannual plan on turbot in the Black Sea.

In the context of the GFCM, the EU is a party to the 2018 Sofia Ministerial Declaration, alongside Bulgaria, Georgia, Moldova, Romania and Türkiye. The Sofia Declaration aims in particular to foster sustainable fisheries and to fight IUU. The declaration is a follow-up of the 2016 Bucharest Declaration.

Under the United Nations environment programme, the Bucharest Convention for the Protection of the Black Sea against pollution was signed in 1992. While EU Member States Bulgaria and Romania are signatory countries, the Bucharest Convention is the only European regional sea convention to which the EU is not a party.[6]

Given that only two of the bordering countries are bound by EU legislation, and one additional coastal state (Türkiye) by GFCM measures, the contribution and level of commitment towards preservation of fisheries resources is uneven, and further weakened by the war in the region.

European Parliament position

Despite the limited area of application of EU legislation within the Black Sea, the European Parliament has played an important role as a co-legislator in the field of fisheries. Parliament has in particular adopted legislation aimed at transposing decisions by the GFCM, to which the EU is a contracting party, into EU law.

Parliament is currently working on a proposal to transpose into EU law GFCM measures adopted in 2021 and 2022. Regarding the Black Sea, the proposed regulation envisages new provisions on sprat, piked (spiny) dogfish and turbot fisheries.

The new legislation would amend Regulation (EU) 2023/2124 on certain provisions for fishing in the GFCM agreement area. The regulation lays down rules for fisheries in the Mediterranean and the Black Sea and covers, in particular, rules regarding fisheries of piked (spiny) dogfish, turbot and rapa whelk as well as rules regarding the use of certain fishing gear in the Black Sea.

Furthermore, Parliament has highlighted its position in several resolutions on subjects relating to fisheries in the Black Sea:

In a resolution of 18 January 2024 on the state of play in the implementation of the CFP and future perspectives, MEPs highlighted the severe impact of the Russian aggression against Ukraine on fishing activities in the Black Sea, and considered the idea of multiannual plans as a management tool for the Black Sea.

On 23 June 2021, Parliament adopted a resolution on the challenges and opportunities for the fishing sector in the Black Sea, in which it underlined the importance of a constructive dialogue with the Black Sea countries that are not members of the EU. It highlighted the environmental challenges affecting the fishing sector, as well as overfishing in the area, and called for efficient remedies.

In a resolution of 8 October 2013 on fisheries restrictions and jurisdictional waters in the Mediterranean and the Black Sea – ways for conflict resolution, MEPs called for measures to combat overfishing, including IUU, a strengthened dialogue between bordering countries, and enhanced environmental protection.

In its resolution of 13 September 2011 on the current and future management of Black Sea fisheries, Parliament pointed to the difficult management situation in the Black Sea, given that only two bordering countries are EU Member States. Members also stressed the need of a special policy for the Black Sea fisheries, and regretted the lack of a common institutional structure for the area.

On 13 December 2007, Parliament adopted a resolution on the shipping disasters in the Kerch Strait in the Black Sea and the subsequent oil pollution, in which it called on the Commission to explore all options to prevent and address further environmental disasters, highlighting in particular cooperation with non-EU countries.

On 19 February 2020, during a meeting of Parliament's Committee on Fisheries, an exchange of views on 'Challenges and opportunities for the fishing sector in the Black Sea' took place. Presentations covered the main concerns regarding the fishing sector in the Black Sea and key aspects for the recovery of sturgeons.

MEPs have also submitted numerous written questions to the European Commission, expressing their concern over the state of the Black Sea and its fisheries. These include in particular questions regarding overfishing, the damage of environmental incidents to marine life, and the risks caused by inadequate waste management. Additionally, the difficult management of fisheries in the Black Sea has been raised, as well as the question of support for fishers affected by the war in Ukraine.

MAIN REFERENCES

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ENDNOTES

1 According to the Commission report on the implementation of the directive, the percentage of species in favourable conservation status in the Black Sea is zero.

2 The turbot biomass dropped from an estimated 1 780 tonnes in 2013 to 993.18 tonnes in 2016.

3 To be considered invasive, the non-indigenous species must adapt to the new area, reproduce, and alter the existing ecosystem.

4 All data except for Ukraine refer to 2022; for Ukraine, the latest data available are from 2020. For Russia, no data are available.

5 Russian participation has been suspended.

6 The EU's proposal to become a party to the convention was met with opposition from Russia, Türkiye and Ukraine.

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